



Rajendra K. Pachauri

We can emerge as a **LEADER IN SOLAR ENERGY** within the next 10 years and show the world a way out of global warming

The one big change that India requires urgently and in large measure is for the population to develop a deep reverence for nature. Indian culture and our traditional beliefs have for ages ensured that nature and its bounty are treated with profound respect and value. In fact, this traditional respect has even taken the shape of religious beliefs such as the case of sacred groves, in which trees are not allowed to be cut. To an extent several river systems in the country, quite apart from the Ganga, are also seen as heaven's gifts that human beings are supposed to respect. However, since we have adopted an economic system essentially borrowed from the developed countries of the West and have preoccupied ourselves with producing and consuming more and more goods and services, ancient traditions and values have been forsaken. As a result, growth and development have progressively caused damage to the environment without questioning or evaluating the extent of this damage. A major revival of our traditional culture and traditions is, therefore, needed now.

Since we live in a world of globalisation, and our progress at every level of society is measured in terms of the output of goods and services, the very first step we need to take is to ensure that our system of income accounting fully reflects costs to the environment. Nowhere, for instance, do we include in the cost of the rapidly growing movement of motor vehicles, the costs that are imposed in the form of air pollution and its health effects. There are enough studies available now that give us a fairly good estimate of these costs, which should be included in the cost of usage of road space in those areas that contribute to air pollution. Such an approach would require the building of expertise and knowhow at a decentralised and local level in municipalities

and other authorities that are responsible for management of our towns and cities. Public awareness would also be essential apart from regulatory and fiscal measures, so that the public itself understands the relevance of these measures and accepts them fully. The polluter must pay as an essential principle for bridging the difference between private costs and social costs. A nationwide drive, however, has to begin from the top. Examples of major national efforts and their success are available even in today's world, and we can learn a great deal from them while bringing about the change that is needed in this country. We have, since the time of Mahatma Gandhi, lost our ability to mount public action on a large scale.

In 1973-74, as a result of the Arab boycott, oil prices in the global market quadrupled within the course of a few days. The world experienced an almost unbearable trauma with some of the poorest countries suffering serious setbacks in their economies. Japan decided to take a series of widespread measures by which their dependence on imported oil could be reduced substantially. As a consequence, several energy intensive industries were shrunk deliberately or shut down completely. Those that remained were subjected to several measures which were adopted to improve the efficiency of energy use. Overall, by the early 1980s, Japan had effectively insulated itself from sudden increases in oil prices or physical disruptions in supply. This example is being mentioned only because this was a remarkable case of government and the public converting a serious problem into an opportunity.

India faces today a similar opportunity in improving the use of natural resources and particularly fossil fuels in the economy. In 1997, The Energy and Resource Institute (TERI) completed a major exercise called GREEN India 2047 which analysed the

Bubble Burst

IN 1973-74, AS A RESULT OF THE ARAB BOYCOTT, OIL PRICES IN THE GLOBAL MARKET QUADRUPLED WITHIN THE COURSE OF A FEW DAYS.